

scour online stores for unique materials that might come at a lower cost. Then buy, ship, and store until you're ready to use them.

7. **Don't skip the plans.** A lot of contractors will tell you that you don't need architectural plans to do your renovation. And in some cases, you don't. But if you're moving fixtures, tearing down walls, or relocating the toilet or any electrical work, then spend the money on an architect. They generally charge between 10 and 20 percent of the overall budget, but it's well worth it to avoid getting into bigger problems later. Finding out in the middle of construction that a fridge doesn't fit or there's not enough counter space in the kitchen is a budgetary nightmare. Architects not only help you visualize the finished project; they help foresee potentially expensive problems so you can avoid them.
8. **If you have to borrow, you can't afford a reno.** In the last few years, the single biggest expense people have put on a line of credit is home renovation. Blame the flood of DIY channels, home improvement, and real estate programs, but banks have largely financed American renovation fever, at an alarming rate. Resist the temptation to go into huge debt to renovate your home. The interest you'll pay over the years of servicing that debt will overshadow the gains you make with the renovation.
9. **Don't over-renovate.** It's called overcapitalizing when you spend more money on your house than the margin you'll reap when you sell it. A colleague of mine once bought a historic rowhouse. Hers was in the middle of two other units. The outside units had upstairs bedrooms because the owners could simply insert a window on the side of each house. After adding a kitchen on the main floor and a basement suite, my colleague looked into adding a second bedroom upstairs, which would entail building stairs, plus dormers on the roof. It would cost a minimum of \$50,000. That's where she stopped short with her